THE DIME GUIDE



You Already Know How to Work

A plain guide to using AI with the experience you already have

Otieno Koduong'o

Your experience. Augmented by AI.

CONTENTS

What is inside

Chapter 1: What AI is, and isn't 3

Chapter 2: How it works, without the maths 6

Chapter 3: What it can and can't reliably do 8

Chapter 4: Finding opportunities in your own work 11

Chapter 5: Asking clearly 14

Chapter 6: Checking the output 17

Chapter 7: Privacy, confidentiality and risk 20

Chapter 8: How your role may change 22

Chapter 9: Your first 30 days 24

Sources 27

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

- Read in order, or jump to any chapter.
- Tap **Bookmark this page** at the bottom of any page. Your bookmarks are listed under **Bookmarks** at the top.
- Bookmarks and your place are saved in this browser only.

CHAPTER 1

What AI is, and isn't

Strip away the hype and see the tool for what it is.

You have heard that AI will change your work. You have also heard it is overhyped. Both can be partly true. Neither tells you what to do on Monday.

This chapter gives you a plain picture of what these tools are. You do not need a technical background. You need the judgment you already have.

What AI is

AI is software that does things we usually link to human thinking. It can work with language, spot patterns and make predictions. It learns these patterns from very large numbers of examples. It does not only follow rules a person wrote out.

When people talk about using AI at work today, they mostly mean chat assistants. You type a request. It writes back. It can draft, summarise, explain and suggest.

What it does when it answers

The tool has learned from a huge amount of text. From that, it has learned which words tend to follow which. When you ask something, it builds an answer that sounds right.

Sounding right is not the same as being right. The tool is not looking up the truth. It is producing a likely answer. Often that answer is good. Sometimes it is wrong, and it says so just as calmly.[1]

Three things it is not

- **Not a search engine.** Some tools can search the web. A plain answer is still not a list of checked sources.
- **Not a colleague who knows your work.** It does not know your clients, your rules or your history unless you tell it.
- **Not a decision-maker.** It can offer options. You choose, and you answer for the choice.

Where it helps

It helps most when you can judge the result yourself:

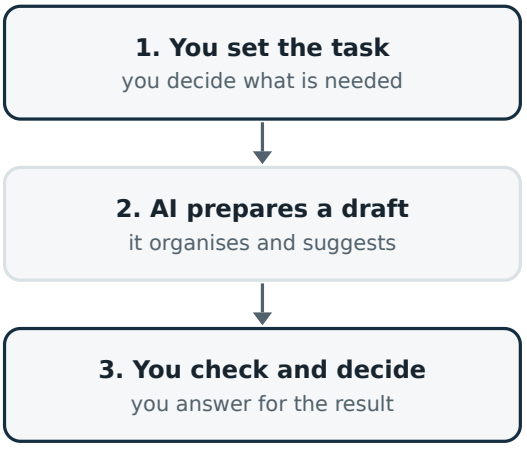
- a first draft you will edit
- a summary of a long document
- rough notes turned into a clear outline
- a plain explanation of something unfamiliar
- questions or options you had not thought of

Where it struggles

- facts and numbers it recalls from memory
- exact calculations
- recent events, unless it can search
- the details of your own organisation
- anything where a believable mistake would be costly

The one idea to keep

> KEY IDEA
>
> **AI prepares. You decide.**



The more it matters if the answer is wrong, the more carefully you check. A routine email needs a quick read. A figure in a client report needs to be traced to its source.

✎ Do this

Pick a low-stakes task. Use your own meeting notes, with nothing confidential in them. Ask an AI assistant to summarise them in five bullets and list three questions the notes leave open. Compare its answer with what you know. What did it get right? What did it miss? Did it add anything you never wrote? Write down one thing you will always check.

IN SHORT

- AI predicts likely words. It does not look up the truth.
- Use it to prepare drafts, summaries and options.
- You decide, and you answer for the choice.

CHAPTER 2

How it works, without the maths

One idea explains most of what goes wrong.

You do not need to understand the machinery. But one idea explains most of what goes wrong, and it is worth five minutes.

It predicts, it does not know

The tool was trained on a very large amount of writing. It learned patterns: what usually comes after what. When you ask a question, it works out a likely answer, word by word.

This is why it writes so smoothly. It is also why it can be wrong. A smooth sentence is easy to produce. A true sentence needs a fact to check against, and the tool does not always have one.

What follows from this

It can make things up. Ask for a source, a quote or a statistic it does not have, and it may invent one that looks real.[1] Names, dates, numbers and references are the weak spots.

Its knowledge has an end date. It learned up to a certain point. After that, it knows nothing, unless the tool can search the web. Ask whether the tool you use can search, and whether it has done so.

It may not remember you. Many tools start fresh each time. Some have a memory feature. Do not assume it knows what you said last week.

It can lose track in long chats. It can only hold so much in view at once. In a very long chat or document, details in the middle can get missed, even by tools built for long text.[2]

It can give different answers. Ask the same thing twice and the wording, and sometimes the content, will differ.

It can lean towards agreeing with you. If your question assumes something, it may go along with it. A leading question gets a leading answer.[3]

When to trust it more

It is more dependable when the answer sits in text you have given it. Summarising your own notes is safer than asking it to recall facts about the world.

It is also better on well-known topics that many people have written about. It is weaker on narrow, recent or local matters.

A simple rule: **text you supply beats facts it recalls.**

When to trust it less

- specific figures, dates and names
- exact quotes and references
- rules and prices that change
- topics few people write about
- anything about your own organisation or clients

Why a confident tone means little

The tool sounds the same whether it is right or wrong. Confidence in its wording is not evidence. Only checking is evidence.

✎ Do this

Ask an AI assistant a question you already know the answer to. Ask it twice, in different words. Compare the answers. Then ask it: "Which parts of your answer are you least sure of?" Notice what changes and what stays the same. This shows you how much weight its answers can bear.

IN SHORT

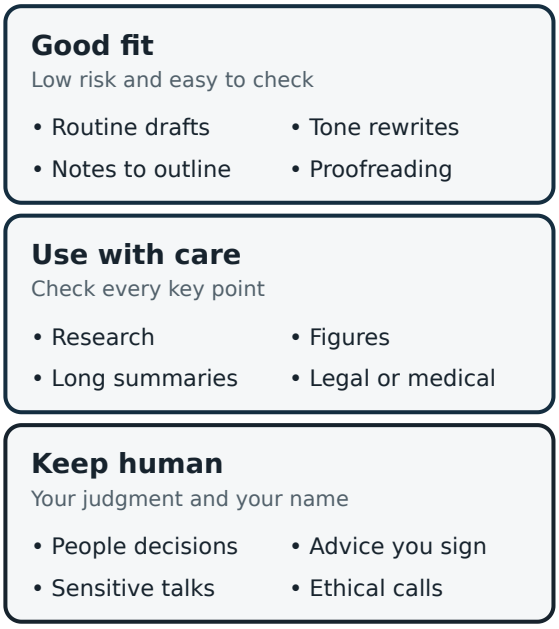
- Smooth writing is not proof of accuracy.
- Names, numbers and sources are the weak spots.
- Text you supply beats facts it recalls.

CHAPTER 3

What it can and can't reliably do

Stop asking if AI is good at your job. Sort your tasks instead.

It is tempting to ask: "Is AI good at my job?" That is the wrong question. Your job is made of many tasks. Some suit AI. Some do not. Your task is to sort them.



Three groups

Good fit. Low risk, and you can check the result quickly.

- drafting routine messages and documents
- rewriting text in a different tone or for a different reader
- turning rough notes into a clear structure
- explaining an idea in plain words
- suggesting options, questions or checklists
- proofreading

Use with care. It can help, but errors are likely or costly. Check every important point.

- research and finding facts
- anything with figures or calculations
- summaries of long or important documents
- working with data
- legal, medical, financial or technical content
- translating something important (have someone fluent check it)

Keep human. The judgment, trust or accountability must be yours.

- final decisions about people, such as hiring, discipline or care
- advice that carries your name or licence
- sensitive conversations
- decisions that are ethical, not just practical
- anything involving confidential information the tool should not see

Three questions to sort any task

1. **Can I check the result?** If you can spot a mistake quickly, AI is safer.
2. **What happens if it is wrong?** A small slip is fine. A serious one is not.
3. **Could I explain that AI helped, and be comfortable?** If not, think again.

Same task, different risk

The task name does not decide the group. The stakes do. Drafting an email to a colleague is a good fit. Drafting an email that sets out a legal position is use with care. The tool is the same. The consequences are not.

✎ Do this

Write down ten tasks from your last working week. Put each in one of the three groups. Then pick one from "Good fit" to try. Keep the list. You will use it in the next chapter.

IN SHORT

- Sort every task: good fit, use with care, keep human.
- Ask: can I check it, and what if it is wrong?
- The stakes decide the group, not the task name.

CHAPTER 4

Finding opportunities in your own work

Start with your work. The tool comes second.

Most people start with a tool and then hunt for a use. It works better the other way round. Start with your work. Then ask where help would be welcome.

Step 1: List your tasks

Look back over the last two weeks. Write down what you actually did. Be specific. "Wrote the Friday update for the team" is better than "communication".

Aim for 15 to 20 tasks. Use your calendar and sent emails to jog your memory.

Step 2: Mark the good candidates

Go through the list and tick any task that fits most of these:

- **You do it again and again.**
- **It involves words or text.** Writing, reading, summarising, sorting.
- **It starts with a blank page,** or a pile of notes.
- **It is more tedious than hard.**
- **You can check the result quickly.**
- **A mistake would be small and easy to fix.**

The more ticks, the better the candidate.

Step 3: Cross out the poor candidates

Put a line through any task that:

- needs confidential information you cannot share with the tool
- depends on knowing a person or situation in depth
- carries serious consequences if it goes wrong
- is mainly about judgment, trust or care

Crossing out is not failure. It tells you where your own skill matters most.

Step 4: Choose three

Pick three tasks from the ticked list. Choose one easy, one medium and one that is a stretch. Start with the easy one.

Do not try to change everything at once. One task, done well, teaches you more than ten done badly.

Step 5: Measure it

For each test, write down three things:

1. How long it took with AI, including checking and fixing.
2. How long it usually takes without.
3. How much you had to change.

Be honest. Sometimes AI saves no time. Checking takes effort, and a poor first draft can cost more than starting yourself. That is a useful result. Drop that task and move on.

A short example

Suppose you write a weekly update for your team. It repeats. It is text. It starts from your notes. You can check it against what you know. A mistake would be small. That is a strong candidate.

Now suppose you decide who gets a promotion. It is not repeated. It depends on knowing people. The consequences are serious. Cross it out.

✎ Do this

Use the ten tasks from Chapter 3, or make a fresh list. Tick, cross out, and choose three. Try the easy one this week. Record the three measures. Keep the notes. They are the start of your own evidence.

IN SHORT

- List your tasks, then tick and cross out.
- Test three, starting with the easy one.
- Measure time and fixes. Drop what does not pay off.

CHAPTER 5

Asking clearly

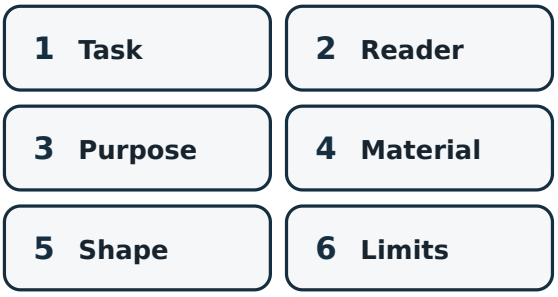
Brief it like a capable new colleague.

The quality of what you get depends on what you ask. This is not a trick. It is the same skill you use when you brief a new colleague.

Imagine a capable person who has just joined. They are quick and willing. They know nothing about your clients, your situation or your standards. What would you tell them?

Six things to include

1. **The task.** What do you want done?
2. **The reader.** Who is it for? What do they know?
3. **The purpose.** What should it achieve?
4. **The material.** Give it the facts, notes or text to work from.
5. **The shape.** Length, format, tone.
6. **The limits.** What to avoid or leave out.



A weak request and a better one

Weak: "Write an update about the project."

Better: "Write a Friday update for my team of eight. They know the project but not this week's delay. Use the notes below. Keep it under 150 words, in a plain and calm tone. Do not add anything that is not in the notes. Notes: [paste notes here]"

The second request takes thirty seconds longer to write. It saves much more than that in rewriting.

Useful phrases

- **"Use only the text below."** This cuts down on invented detail.
- **"If something is missing, say so. Do not guess."** This gives it permission to admit gaps.
- **"Ask me questions first if you need more."** This lets it check it understood.
- **"Give me two different versions."** This shows you options.

Work in rounds

Your first request is rarely the last. Treat it as a conversation. Say what to change: "Shorter." "Less formal." "Put the delay first." "Remove the second paragraph."

If it goes off track, do not keep patching. Start a new chat and write a clearer first request, using what you learned.

Avoid leading questions

If you ask, "Why is this plan good?" you will get reasons it is good. Try: "What are the strengths and weaknesses of this plan?" A neutral question gets a more balanced answer.

Keep your own voice

AI writing can sound generic. Give it an example of your own writing and ask it to match the style. Then edit. The final words should sound like you.

✎ Do this

Take the easy task you chose in Chapter 4. Write your request using the six parts. Run it. Then improve it twice by telling the tool what to change. Compare the first and last versions. Keep your best request. You can reuse it.

IN SHORT

- Give the task, reader, purpose, material, shape and limits.
- Say "use only the text below".
- Improve in rounds. Start fresh if it drifts.

CHAPTER 6

Checking the output

The step that makes AI safe to use.

This is the most important skill in the book. Everything else depends on it.

Checking is not a sign that AI has failed. It is the professional step. You would check a junior colleague's work before it went to a client. Treat AI the same way.

What to check

- **Facts.** Are they true? Are they relevant here?
- **Numbers.** Do they add up? Do they match the source?
- **Names and dates.** Are they right?
- **Quotes and sources.** Do they exist? Do they say what is claimed?
- **What is missing.** What should be there that is not?
- **What was added.** Is there anything you did not provide?
- **Tone.** Would this suit the person reading it?

How to check

Trace it. Find the original. Do not accept a figure because it looks reasonable.

Redo it. Recalculate numbers yourself in a spreadsheet or calculator.

Open every source. If it names a report or a link, find it. Read the passage.

Compare with your text. If you asked it to use your notes, scan for anything that is not in them.

Ask for the evidence. Say: "Show me where in my text you got that." If it cannot, be suspicious.

Take a break. Read it again later. Errors are easier to spot with fresh eyes.

Match the checking to the stakes

- **Low stakes** (a casual message): read it through once.
- **Medium stakes** (an internal report): check key facts and numbers.
- **High stakes** (a client document, a decision, anything with your name or licence): check everything, and have a second person look if you can.

Warning signs

- very specific details with no source
- perfect-sounding quotes

- numbers that are suspiciously round
- a confident answer on an unusual topic
- references you cannot find

Asking the tool to check itself

You can ask it, "What might be wrong in this?" This sometimes catches problems. But it is not proof. The same tool that made the mistake may miss it. Your own check is the one that counts.

Learn from your errors

Keep a short note of what AI got wrong. After a month you will see a pattern. You will know where to look first.

✎ Do this

Take the result from your Chapter 5 task. Run the checks above. Note every error and every thing you changed. Then decide the checking level you will use for this type of task in future.

IN SHORT

- Check facts, numbers, names, quotes and gaps.
- Match the effort to the stakes.
- Your check counts. The tool's self-check does not.

CHAPTER 7

Privacy, confidentiality and risk

Know what never to paste in.

The fastest way to get into trouble with AI is to share something you should not. This chapter helps you avoid that. Rules differ by country, employer and profession, so treat what follows as a starting point, not legal advice.

A simple test

Before you paste anything in, ask: **would I be comfortable sending this to a stranger?** If the answer is no, do not put it in.

What to keep out

- names and details of clients, patients, students or staff
- anything covered by a confidentiality agreement
- passwords, access codes and private keys
- your employer's internal plans, figures or contracts
- other people's personal details
- anything the law or your profession says must stay private

Know where your words go

What happens to what you type depends on the tool and the settings. Some tools may keep your conversations. Some may use them to improve the product, unless you switch that off. Others, set up by an employer, may handle data differently.

Do not guess. Read the tool's privacy settings and policy. If you use it for work, ask your employer which tools are approved.

Remove the details

Often you can get the help you need without the sensitive parts. Replace names with labels such as "Client A". Remove addresses, account numbers and anything that identifies a person. Describe the situation, not the people.

Be careful. Details can sometimes identify someone even without a name. If in doubt, leave it out.

Check the rules that apply to you

Many workplaces now have a policy on AI. Some professions have guidance from their regulator or professional body. If you are not sure, ask. It is better to ask first than to explain afterwards.

Other risks to keep in mind

Ownership. Who owns what AI produces can be unclear, and whether it copies someone else's work is a separate question. Rules differ by country. In the United States, the Copyright Office has said that purely AI-generated material is not protected by copyright, and that typing a request alone is not enough to make you its author. Your own edits and arrangement can count.[4] For anything you will publish or sell, find out where you stand.

Bias. AI learns from human writing, so it can repeat unfair assumptions. Be especially careful with anything about people: hiring, lending, health, education.

Tools that act for you. Some tools can send messages, change files or book things. A mistake there is harder to undo. Start with tools that only read and suggest. Give more freedom slowly.

Scams. AI is also used to make convincing fake messages and voices.[6] A message that sounds right is not proof it is real. Check urgent or unusual requests by another route.

If something goes wrong

If you paste something you should not have, do not hide it. Tell the right person early. Quick action limits the harm. Most workplaces would rather hear about a slip quickly than discover it later.

✎ Do this

Write three rules for yourself, such as: "Never paste client names. Use only approved tools for work. Check anything that will be sent outside." Find out your employer's policy on AI. If there is none, ask who decides.

IN SHORT

- Do not paste what you would not send a stranger.
- Know where your words go, and follow your employer's rules.
- If you slip, say so early.

CHAPTER 8

How your role may change

Think clearly about your own work.

Nobody knows exactly how AI will change work. Be wary of anyone who says they do. Some predict disaster. Some promise an easy future. Both are guesses.

What you can do is think clearly about your own work.

Tasks change before jobs do

Often the first change is not that a job disappears. It is that parts of it get quicker. A large study by the International Labour Organization found that most jobs are only partly exposed, and that AI is more likely to change tasks than to replace whole roles. That is an estimate, not a promise.[5] First drafts, summaries and routine messages take less time. That can free you for other work. It can also raise what people expect you to produce.

What may matter more

As the quick parts get easier, other things stand out:

- **Judgment.** Knowing what is right, not just what is plausible.
- **Trust.** Clients and colleagues want a person they can rely on.
- **Knowing the situation.** The history, the people, the unwritten rules.
- **Checking.** Someone must catch the mistakes.
- **Accountability.** When something goes wrong, someone answers for it.

These are things you already have. Years of experience are the material AI cannot supply.

Skills worth building

You do not need to become technical. Three skills carry the most weight:

1. **Asking clearly.** Briefing the tool well.
2. **Checking carefully.** Catching what is wrong.
3. **Knowing your field.** The deeper your knowledge, the better you can judge the output.

Things to watch for

Leaning on it too much. If you stop doing the thinking, your own skill can fade. Keep doing the hard parts yourself.

Sameness. If everyone uses the same tools the same way, work can start to look alike. Your own voice and view are worth protecting.

Pressure. You may feel you should do more, faster. Decide what is a sensible pace for you and your work.

Stay curious, not frightened

Fear leads to rushed choices. So does hype. A steady approach works better: learn a little, test it, keep what helps, and drop what does not.

Talk to colleagues. Ask how they use it. Share what you learn. You will find others are also working it out.

Look after your career

Keep a record of what you have tried and what it achieved. This helps you speak about AI with confidence. It also shows you are thoughtful about change, which is worth something to employers and clients.

✎ Do this

Write down three things in your work that only you can do. Then write one task you would happily hand to a tool. Look at both lists. They show where your value lies, and where you can save time.

IN SHORT

- Tasks change before jobs do. Nobody can promise how.
- Judgment, trust and accountability gain weight.
- Build three skills: ask clearly, check carefully, know your field.

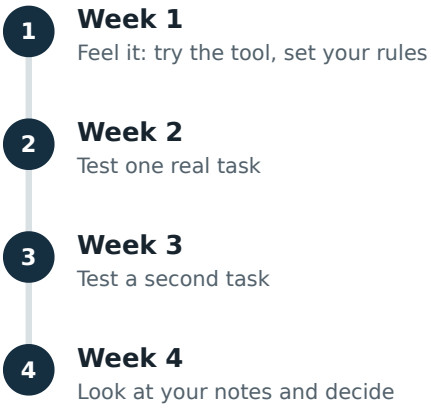
CHAPTER 9

Your first 30 days

A small, safe start. Thirty days.

You do not need to become an expert. You need a small, safe start. This plan gives you one.

Spend about 20 to 30 minutes at a time, a few times a week. Keep notes as you go.



Week 1: Get a feel for it

- Choose one AI assistant. Check its privacy settings.
- Write your three rules from Chapter 7.
- Try the exercises from Chapters 1 and 2 with non-confidential material.
- Notice what it does well and where it slips.

Week 2: Test one real task

- Use your list from Chapters 3 and 4. Pick the easy task.
- Write a clear request using the six parts from Chapter 5.
- Run it and improve it in two rounds.
- Check the result using Chapter 6. Record the time and the errors.

Week 3: Test a second task

- Choose a different task from your list.
- Apply what you learned. Reuse what worked.
- Try one task where the tool only helps you think, such as listing options or questions.
- Again record time saved and what you had to fix.

Week 4: Decide

Look at your notes. For each task, ask:

1. Did it save time, after checking?
2. Was the quality as good as mine, or better?
3. Was I comfortable with the risk?

Keep what passed. Drop what did not. There is no prize for using AI on everything.

Then

- Turn your best requests into a small set you can reuse.
- Tell a colleague what you found. Teaching helps you learn.
- Set a date in three months to review again. The tools will have changed. Your judgment will still be yours.

A note on setbacks

Some tests will go badly. The tool will invent something, or miss the point, or waste your time. This is normal. Each failure teaches you where the edges are.

If you feel overwhelmed, do less. One task a week is enough to learn.

Where you are now

After 30 days, you will know what AI is, what it can and cannot do, and how to use it with care. You will have your own evidence from your own work.

You already knew how to work. Now you know how AI can work with you.

AI assists. You remain accountable.

IN SHORT

- Week 1 feel it. Week 2 test. Week 3 test again. Week 4 decide.
- Keep what saves time and passes your checks.
- Review again in three months.

BACK MATTER

Sources and what they support

Checked in October 2026. Whether a tool remembers earlier chats, and what it does with what you type, varies by tool and is not covered by these sources. Check your own tool's settings.

1. **How these tools work and why they make things up (Chapters 1 and 2).** A reference definition of a large language model describes it as trained to predict the next unit of text, and notes that it can produce fluent but wrong statements, including invented citations. casrai.org
2. **Details in the middle of long input get missed (Chapter 2).** Liu and others, "Lost in the Middle: How Language Models Use Long Contexts", Transactions of the Association for Computational Linguistics, 2024. arxiv.org
3. **Leaning towards agreeing with you (Chapter 2).** Sharma and others, "Towards Understanding Sycophancy in Language Models", Anthropic, 2023. anthropic.com
4. **Ownership of AI output (Chapter 7).** US Copyright Office, "Copyright and Artificial Intelligence, Part 2: Copyrightability" (January 2025), as summarised by the Copyright Alliance. The position is specific to the United States and is not legally binding. copyrightalliance.org
5. **Tasks changing more than whole jobs (Chapter 8).** Gmyrek, Berg and Bescond, "Generative AI and Jobs: A global analysis of potential effects on job quantity and quality", ILO Working Paper 96. ilo.org
6. **Convincing fake voices (Chapter 7).** The US Federal Trade Commission has warned about scammers cloning voices to make "family emergency" calls sound real, as reported by US local news outlets. The FTC page itself was not found.

Everything else in this book is general advice drawn from common professional practice, not from a specific study. Source numbers match the small numbers in the text.